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DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA
GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

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Israel says it intends to take control of the whole of Gaza

TRUCKS OF BABY FOOD TO BE FIRST AID DELIVERY EXPECTED INTO THE STRIP

JERUSALEM

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said yesterday that Israel will "take control" of the whole of Gaza, as the military pressed a newly intensified campaign in the war-ravaged territory.

After Israel announced it would let a "basic amount" of food into the Gaza Strip, Netanyahu said it was necessary to prevent a famine for "diplomatic reasons".

In Gaza, rescuers said air strikes killed at least 52 people, after the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) announced it had begun "extensive ground operations" against Hamas. The IDF asked Palestinians in Khan Younis, one of Gaza's biggest cities, and two other nearby areas to leave immediately.

Intense fighting

"The fighting is intense and we are making progress. We will take control of all the territory of the Strip," Netanyahu said in a video posted on Telegram.

"We will not give up. But in order to succeed, we must act in a way that cannot be stopped."



Displaced Palestinians walk with pots of cooked food collected at a charity distribution centre in Jabalia yesterday.

AFP

Israel has come under mounting international pressure, including from key backer the United States, to lift a total blockade it imposed on Gaza more than two months ago.

"We must not let the popu-

lation (of Gaza) sink into famine, both for practical and diplomatic reasons," Netanyahu said, adding that even friends of Israel would not tolerate "images of mass starvation".

Israel said yesterday it was

letting trucks of baby food into the Gaza Strip, the first aid to be admitted since the Israeli government announced the partial lifting of the two-month blockade.

— Agencies

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